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The Subject Objectified: Mimetic Desire and the Male Gaze in *Madame Bovary*

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A creative writing professor once told me that in order to write a good character, one must align all the character's actions with their underlying desires. Desires, she said, are what turn a character into a person. Since then, I have always used desire as a 'way in' to the books I read; I can always understand a character better if I understand what they want. In Flaubert's novel *Madame Bovary*, the answer to this question appears to be self-evident: Emma desires passion and romance, which she attempts to satisfy by having dramatic dead-end affairs with multiple men. But to ask *what* a character desires is one thing, and to ask *why* is another. Emma's desires, according to Flaubert's framing, are naive and narcissistic, but he's not explicit about where they come from. Is Emma a product of her time? Is she a product of literature? Does Flaubert mean to argue female desire is futile? In this essay, I will be exploring the *why* of Emma's desire using René Girard's theory of mimetic desire and a consideration of how gender shapes the process of developing desire. I argue that Emma's desires are modeled after—or, to use Girard's term, *mediated* by—not only the romantic heroines in literature, but also the male characters and broader male gaze by which she is surrounded, ultimately turning her desire onto herself as a force of subjugation and making her life unlivable.

Girard's theory of "triangular desire" is an apt framework for understanding desire in *Madame Bovary*. The concept comes from his 1961 book *Deceit, Desire, and the Novel*, in which he first explains triangular desire with Don Quixote: "the disciple pursues objects which are determined for him, or at least seem to be determined for him, by the model of all chivalry" (Girard 2). Desire can be understood as a triangle between three figures: the self (the subject; most often the protagonist for Girard), the other/the "mediator" (the "model of all chivalry"), and the object of desire. The protagonist's desires, then, are fundamentally *mimetic*: they are not their own but an imitation of the desires of the figure(s) they look up to. Girard points to *Madame*

*Bovary* as an example of this structure, where Emma's desire for romance is modeled after the heroines of the books she reads. The triangle he sees is between Emma (subject), the romantic heroines (mediator), and men (object).

In this structure of triangular desire, moreover, the object of desire appears to the subject to be something it is not. Girard writes, "the mediator's prestige is imparted to the object of desire and confers upon it an illusory value. Triangular desire is the desire which transfigures its object" (Girard 17). This is how he explains Emma's naivete: she "would not have taken Rudolph for a Prince Charming had she not been imitating romantic heroines" (Girard 18). This transfiguration is an essential feature of mimetic desire, and it will become important for understanding Emma's position in the alternate triangle of desire.

It's important to note here that Flaubert defines Emma's desire as specifically *feminine*. He first introduces her desires in the context of the female characters in her books:

Through Walter Scott, later on, she fell in love with historical events, dreamed of old chests, guard-rooms and minstrels. She would have liked to live in some old manor-house, like those long-waisted chatelaines who, in the shade of pointed arches, spent their days leaning on the stone, chin in hand, watching a cavalier with white plume galloping on his black horse from the distant fields (Flaubert 34).

These visions of an ideal life are grounded in aesthetics and the visibility of herself as a certain kind of woman. She idolizes "Joan of Arc, Heloise, Agnes Sorel" and others because they live a specific aesthetic life as women. Part of this life is desiring romance with a man, but it is also wanting to *be seen by the man* as he approaches from "distant fields." Thus Emma's desires are specific not to *Emma*, but to *women*; one could take Emma's desires and apply them to a

different female character, but one couldn't apply them to Charles or Rodolphe. This is why Girard's analysis is unsatisfactory: it doesn't consider the fact that Emma's desires are rooted in her gendered experience. *Madame Bovary* needs a revised triangle of desire.

Defining the mediator of Emma's desires is not so simple as pointing to the characters Emma points to. According to Girard, the mediator(s) are the literary romantic heroines like in the above passage, but he doesn't actually do much close reading to support this claim. Emma's reading in the convent is accompanied by her "star[ing] in dazzled amazement at the names of the unknown authors, most of whom had used a title—count or viscount—when signing their contribution" (Flaubert 35). Though Emma herself doesn't make note of it, Flaubert indicates that the authors of these books were primarily men. Emma falls in love with her objects of desire "through Walter Scott" (emphasis added); what she desires, then, is what a man imagines a woman desires. The women she imitates are not real women, they are what men think women should be. Therefore, there are actually *two* working mediators of Emma's desire: the romantic heroines, and the male perspective that constructs the romantic heroines.

Emma's desires, then, are uniquely female in that they are perpetually defined by the male, who, in turn, limits the potential for those desires to be fulfilled. To a certain extent, Emma recognizes her desire as a limiting force. Before Berthe is born, she reflects on how gender shapes the potential of one's life:

She wanted a son [...] A man, at least, is free, free to explore all passions and all countries, to surmount obstacles, to induce in the most exotic pleasures. But a woman is constantly thwarted. At once passive and compliant, she has to contend with both the weakness of her body and the subjection imposed by the law. Her will, like the veil

attached to her hat, flutters with every breeze; always there is desire inviting her on, and, always, convention holding her back (Flaubert 79-80).

Emma views her position as a woman as stuck between two opposing forces, desire and convention, but she can't locate the source of her desires or her limiters; they simply "flutter." The active verb "thwarted" in this passage, however, has an implicit actor: Emma is limited by the male perspective that, in this era, had a new dominion over "convention" (Birken). Women must have passion to satisfy the man's aesthetic vision of womanhood, but to pursue it in reality is impossible; one would be rejected by men just as Emma is rejected. Desire and convention are irreconcilable, and desire becomes, for man upon woman, to be a force of subjugation. This manifests, for Emma, as a particular perspective on *herself*.

If it is instead men who are the primary mediator of desire, Emma's object of desire must be an imitation of their desires. The male characters in *Madame Bovary* are characterized as desiring different variations of the same thing. They want to be known as great: Homais desires attention and fame, Lheureux desires fortune, Charles desires fame through medical and scientific progress. Even Emma's lovers do not primarily desire a romantic relationship; their relationship with Emma is always the second priority in their lives, while for Emma it is always the first. The catch is that they want both at the same time, where their greatness is the *objective* of desire, and the woman is the *object* of desire. Thus Emma must desire a passionate life like the romantic heroines, admire men admiring her like the romantic heroines, view herself as a secondary object of desire, and pursue meaningful things like 'progress.' In an attempt to reconcile all the moving parts of things she is supposed to desire, Emma's object of desire *becomes herself* as she attempts to cater to the desires of men.

Emma turns specifically to self-consciousness and consumerism when she understands

herself as an object of desire. Her narcissism, it seems, can be blamed on the male expectation of her to be an aesthetic object of desire. In the first half of the novel, there are a handful of moments where Flaubert ‘zooms in’ through the eyes of Emma’s lovers, noticing the little details of her appearance. An example of this is when Charles notices the “little beads of sweat” on Emma’s shoulders (Flaubert 21). Fingernails become a motif throughout the novel, as they represent moments in which Flaubert wants us to pay attention to *how* a certain character is looking at another. While these moments in the first half of the novel are from the perspective of the male characters, there is a shift of this detail noticing. After some time of marriage, it is through Emma’s eyes that we zoom in to the details. The first instance of this is when she notices Léon’s nails on page 84. From that point forward, however, these moments shift to be through Emma’s eyes and with a focus on herself. “It was for him [Rodolphe] that she filed her fingernails with the precision of an artist, for him that there was never enough cold cream on her skin, nor enough patchouli scenting her handkerchiefs” (Flaubert 166). Emma’s attention to the small details of her appearance are attempts to create herself in the image of the woman the man wants her to be. Emma’s pattern of consumption, too, represents the pressure she feels to turn herself into the ideal object of desire. To be the object of desire is, to Emma, to constantly refashion herself into who she thinks the male perspective wants her to be.

As her own object of desire, Emma can never completely satisfy any expectation of existence. This is where the idea of transfiguration of the object of desire returns: if Emma is her own object of desire, she is fated to view herself as something she is not, thus forever wanting herself to be something she will never be. This my theory as to why Emma ultimately commits suicide at the end of the novel. Death is the end of triangular desire, writes Girard in the conclusion of his book, but in *Madame Bovary*, death is the end of triangular desire that makes

living impossible.

*Madame Bovary* is ultimately a novel about wanting to be what others want you to be. Girard's concept of triangular desire is a perfect way of conceptualizing these relations, but by considering how gender influences the experience of this triangle, I have revised Girard's to be instead Emma (subject), men (mediator, other), Emma (object). Because the women she imitates are actually constructed by men, Emma as a character is also constructed by men. Her self-consciousness of her appearance is an attempt to be the perfect object of desire, but when her imitation of the romantic heroines and of the male gaze ultimately never line up, she understands her existence as futile and unlivable. I'd like to think of Emma's suicide as a radical act of resistance to the patriarchy, but this is, in all likelihood, a bit of a stretch. If nothing else, Emma Bovary reminds female readers to think critically about what mechanisms—and who—threaten(s) to determine their dreams for them.

Works Cited

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